

# Lab: The Body Thinks Too

## Objective

Explore embodied cognition through reflective journaling that reveals how bodily states shape thinking, decision-making, and understanding through the lens of pattern-feeling without numbers.

## Prerequisites

- A quiet, comfortable space for 25 minutes
- Willingness to engage in reflective journaling
- No prior experience required

## Part 1: Arriving (5 minutes)

Sit quietly with your journal. Take three slow breaths. Before writing anything, check in with your body. Notice any sensations, feelings, or subtle knowings that are present right now.

Notice: you are thinking right now. But where is the thinking happening? Is it only in your head? Scan your body for signs of cognitive activity -- tension in the forehead, a feeling in the gut, the hands wanting to gesture.

*Write your response here*

(Where in your body do you notice thinking happening? What is the bodily quality of your current thoughts?)

## Part 2: Somatic Markers (7 minutes)

Think of a decision you are facing. Through pattern-feeling without numbers, bring one option to mind and scan your body. Notice the felt response -- openness or constriction, warmth or coolness, ease or tension. Now bring the other option to mind. What shifts?

*Write your response here*

(Describe the bodily responses to each option. Did your body have a preference before your mind decided?)

## Part 3: Posture and Thought (7 minutes)

Explore how the body's position shapes cognition. Try thinking in a slumped posture versus an upright one versus while moving. Through pattern-feeling without numbers, notice how each configuration changes the quality of your thinking.

*Write your response here*

(How did posture and movement affect your thinking? What does this reveal about the body's role in cognition?)

## Part 4: Reflection (5 minutes)

Through pattern-feeling without numbers, reflect on the relationship between body and mind.

Write your response here

(How does this lab change your understanding of where thinking happens? How is embodied cognition different from brain-only cognition?)

Reflection Table

| Dimension                            | What I Noticed | Active Inference Connection                  |
|--------------------------------------|----------------|----------------------------------------------|
| Initial awareness                    |                | Baseline generative model state              |
| Embodied exploration                 |                | Prediction error through direct experience   |
| Pattern-feeling without numbers lens |                | Course-specific perspective on cognition     |
| Integration                          |                | Updated understanding through bodily knowing |

Discussion

Consider how pattern-feeling without numbers reveals aspects of cognition that other perspectives might miss. In Active Inference, every perspective changes the precision weighting of different signals, revealing different dimensions of the same underlying process of free energy minimization.